

EAST

A thoughtful comparison of the ongoing economic revolutions in China and India, Khanna's book juxtaposes stories of firms, personalities and projects from the two emerging powers of the world



ILLUSTRATION: ANITA

pitifully unsubstantial. India's curiosity sorely needs a quick Chinese enlargement.

Though this is, on the whole, a sensible conclusion, Khanna could have spent a bit more time thinking about the unresolved strategic and political tussles between the two nations. Doesn't a business-and-learning discourse clash with the security discourse of the two states? My point is not that neither business nor learning can take place unless the border disagreement is resolved. But it should be recognised that Sino-Indian relationship will always be shot through with a profound ambivalence. What is called realism in international relations will continue to generate a lack of trust in each other's strategic intentions. India and China will do business with each other, but a passionate embrace for

exploitation of synergies is highly improbable.

The author's view of caste will also not be acceptable to most serious students of Indian politics. He finds India's caste politics distasteful; it is also, in his view, highly injurious to economic progress. I don't think caste politics can be judged this way. Nowhere in the world has any pre-modern, vertical, birth-based social order—in which the top echelons had all the privileges and treated those at the bottom with disdain and contempt—disappeared without considerable churning and violence. Those treated shabbily for centuries are simply using the newly available democratic means to assert their power. It is not a pretty sight, but it is a democratic inevitability. It should also be noted that south India, which witnessed an undermining of the caste order by the late 1960s, is now booming. Millions of entrepreneurs, big and small, appear to have emerged from the lower rungs of south India's traditional caste order. If anything, given his main thesis, Khanna should welcome a politically induced expansion of the entrepreneurial pool.

Such disagreements notwithstanding, Khanna's book is a brilliant achievement. It deserves to be widely read.

EXCERPT

Growth on Track

However interesting it may be to examine whether India's infrastructure should be privately or publicly owned, perhaps more useful is to take a closer look on the ground at the damages to daily life wrought by India's political paralysis. One example is Indian Railways, originally installed by the British in 1853 and now employing more than 1.6 million people, making it the world's largest commercial or utility employer. The trains travel the length and width of India, covering a total of 39,462 miles. As a boy I often traveled a small portion of those miles in summer trips with my family from Delhi to Bombay.

The Hazrat Nizamuddin Train Station is only a few minutes' drive from my grandmother's imposing brick house in old Delhi where my schoolboy journeys began, but it took my family a half hour to navigate the narrow, snaking lanes, *galees*, congested with street hawkers, roadside barbers, and meandering cows. When we finally reached the station, which was ancient even in the 1970s, we were accosted by *coolies* (porters) dressed in unwashed red uniforms, the standard government-issue attire, and *pagrees*, cloth headdresses. I remember emerging from the car to a crush of people, baggage, and stray dogs. Families stood, sat, or milled about, patiently waiting for a train that would leave at some future, indeterminate time. My father engaged a *coolie*, who piled our suitcases impossibly high on his wiry frame and ran improbably fast through the crowd to our train, where he was appropriately compensated by my frazzled father. Before boarding the train, typically a dirty brown row of cars with cream-colored roofs, we joined the other travelers peering at a seating chart posted at the end of each compartment. Invariably one or two passengers found that their month-old